

Jayden Rice

4/7/26

Reflective Essay

When I first started college, I thought being educated meant getting the knowledge you needed to land a job. It felt like a checklist. Take the right classes, pass them, and move on. If something did not directly apply to what I wanted to do, especially as someone focused on software and app development, I would question why I even had to learn it. Over the past four semesters, that mindset has shifted a lot. I still care about practical skills, but I no longer see education as just a means to an end. Now I think of it more as an experience that shapes how you think, how you approach problems, and how you understand both yourself and other people.

A lot of that shift came from readings in my Scholars classes that stuck with me more than I expected. One of the biggest was *Paradise Lost*. What stayed with me most was the idea of pride, especially through Satan's character. His refusal to submit, even after losing everything, feels powerful at first, but it is also clearly self-destructive. The idea that it is "better to reign in Hell than serve in Heaven" sounds strong on the surface, but the more I thought about it, the more I saw how it reflects a mindset that can trap you. That made me reflect on ambition in my own life. There is a difference between wanting to build something meaningful and letting pride take over to the point where you cannot step back or change direction. That is something I have become more aware of, especially when I am working on my own projects. So I try not to have so much pride anymore on certain subjects and learn when I have to change.

Another example that shaped how I think was Don Quixote. At first, it seemed like a story about someone out of touch with reality, but the more I paid attention, the more it felt like it was asking a deeper question about how people choose to see the world. Don Quixote's perspective is flawed, but there is also something intentional about the way he holds onto it. That made me think about how perception influences behavior and decisions. It also made me more aware that people are often acting based on their own version of reality, not necessarily what is objectively true. That idea has stuck with me outside of class more than I expected.

Being in the Scholars program also changed how I approach my own field. Outside of class, I spend a lot of time building SaaS applications and websites for clients. Before, I separated that from school. School was something to get through, and building was what actually mattered. Now I see more overlap. Learning how to write, think critically, and understand people actually helps me when I am building products. A good app is not just code. It is understanding how people think and how they make decisions. Because of that, I have started to take more from classes that I originally thought had nothing to do with my major.

Over the past year, I have also grown in how I work. I have learned how to discipline myself and be more patient when doing a task. I used to think that doing things as fast as possible was the best approach, but a lot of times you get better results from a slower and more methodical way of working. I saw this clearly when building my own applications. If you rush, you end up creating problems that are harder to fix later. I had to learn that building something like a SaaS

application requires a structured and careful approach, or you risk the integrity of the entire system. That experience forced me to slow down and think more intentionally, and that mindset has carried over into my academic work as well.

Looking back, being educated now means something different to me than it did when I started. It is not just about what you know, but how you think and how you grow as a person. Even if I do not use something in a direct or conventional way, it still shapes my perspective. The Scholars program played a big role in that shift. It pushed me to engage with ideas I would not have explored on my own and helped me see value in learning beyond immediate usefulness. At this point, I see education as something that builds both skill and character, and that is something I did not fully understand before.